dangerous ties to Islamic states to the west. In reality, the conquest created major tensions with British India.[48]

After its annexation of Arakan, Britain developed an increased interest in the wider region, and a series of conflicts followed. As ever, conquest of a small portion of a country meant the British then feared attack from the remaining independent areas. In turn those fears were linked to specific incidents to give a pretext for further conquest. The results were predictable. The British had annexed the entire territory of Burma by the mid-1880s.

The colonial era (1824–1948)

Outline

Up to this point in time, the histories of Burma and Arakan were largely separate, or at least had no more in common than most neighbouring states do. But from 1784 the two were going to be inextricably linked. After the British conquest of Arakan in 1826, tensions persisted with the Burmese kings. The Second Anglo-Burmese War took place in 1852 and resulted in British control over southern Burma, which left upper Burma completely isolated from the rest of the world. The Third Anglo-Burmese War ended in 1885 and by 1886 the British had created a formal division between 'Ministerial Burma' (basically Rangoon and the Irrawaddy region) and the 'Frontier Areas'.[49] In turn, this created a clear division between a central region dominated by the Burman majority and outlying regions in which a complex patchwork of ethnic groups lived alongside one another. These divisions created strictly enforced internal borders and were combined with limits on internal migration. Burma was designated as a separate administrative state to India in 1937 and the borders were drawn on the basis of state borders that had existed just before the war of 1824–6. So the new administrative unit thus integrated Arakan into what was to become, a mere ten years later, the newly independent country of Burma. This purely administrative decision is what led to the situation we are in today.

Burmese nationalists resented British rule and one source of unrest was the lack of support the British gave to the Buddhist religious hierarchy.[50] Under the previous kingdoms, secular authority had in part been derived from being willing to support Buddhism. So to Burmese nationalists the